Peer Learning Conference & Report

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1. Summary of Group Presentation

In our group, we explored the nature of data collection in modern society. We specifically addressed the effects of monitoring people via the data gathered by both governments and big corporations, including the monitoring of social media and monitoring in the workplace, as well as face recognition, and their effects on fundamental human rights. We selected this subject due to its timeliness in a 2026 digital environment where information is the main currency of the world economy, allowing it to be exchanged in exchange of convenience without the comprehensive awareness of the ethical costs over the long term. The main point that we wanted to convey was that surveillance is not an impartial safety mechanism but this is a practice that must be subject to strict philosophical examination in order to make sure that it does not compromise privacy, consent, and personal autonomy. The evaluation of these technologies in the light of Hobbes, Machiavelli, and Aristotle allowed us to offer a set of tools to assess what constraints should be imposed on data gathering in a digital society. We reasoned that in the absence of an ethical framework, surveillance may turn into a control mechanism instead of a protection mechanism.

2. Key Group Insights and Analysis

Our group discussion and presentation highlighted the invisible costs of ubiquitous technology, focusing on how the modern social contract is fundamentally changing and potentially fading. Our main argument is that today’s pervasive surveillance by technology companies undermines the idea of informed, voluntary consent, resulting in a significant asymmetry of power where users bear risks they cannot fully understand. This insight underscores how corporations possess information and influence, while users are often unaware of how their online traces shape their behaviours. Another important finding from our discussion was the "chilling effect" of this

surveillance—not simply catching bad actors, but altering everyone's psychology and behaviour under constant observation. This sparked debate among our group about whether safety and security are worth the cost of lost anonymity. Some favoured vigilance in preventing crime, while others argued stability outweighs privacy concerns—and that motivations for surveillance may be more about power than protection. Ultimately, this experience revealed how technology can serve as a tool for political power and psychological manipulation rather than merely public service. We concluded that more transparency and ethical regulation should be applied to the creation and use of monitoring algorithms.

3. Engagement with Course Thinkers and Concepts

In order to ground our discussion, I made an emphasis on the view of Aristotle on the end of the state and the need for human flourishing, or Eudaimonia. In his Politics, Aristotle stated that a state was created to attain a good life, not to survive and live. I believe that this notion is the most crucial concept when it comes to digital ethics since it compels us to look past the "security" metrics that are usually applied to excuse surveillance. When a state is equipped to track all actions through digital tools, then this discourages the cultivation of moral virtue since the issue of virtue entails the freedom to do the right thing without being forced by the knowledge of external monitoring. A life of continuous self-censorship is the opposite of how we can become our full potential as political animals (Zoon Politikon). I also incorporated the course idea of the "Golden Mean" in order to deal with the balance of the privacy of the data. The ethics proposed by Aristotle indicate that virtue consists of a median position between two extremes; in this regard, complete anonymity (which permits harming without accountability) and complete transparency (which will result in tyranny) are all ethical vices. A thriving society needs to strike a balance that will safeguard the personal right of a person to nurture his or her personality

privately and at the same time retain a secure society. Moreover, the contemporary use of Predictive Policing is also a direct contradiction of the Aristotelian philosophy of human reason and the ability to develop. The idea of these systems dehumanizing people and establishing their future actions by relying on historical trends deprives a person of their human dignity and chances of developing morals. These ideas allowed me to become more critical because they demonstrated that digital surveillance is not only a policy problem, but a human agency and a good life threat underlying it.

4. Personal Reflection and Relevance

Meditating on this subject has made a major change in my individual philosophy and the attitude I hold towards the digital mediums that I operate on a daily basis. Prior to this course, my understanding of surveillance was based on an abstract trade-off between security and existential non-involvement since I perceived that I had nothing to hide. Nevertheless, this process has led me to understand that the concept of privacy does not mean hiding, but rather the freedom to shape oneself and define oneself without the restrictive burden of something permanent and immutable in an electronic auditing system. This especially applies to my future career goals, in which I will probably be tasked with dealing with sensitive data and be able to make decisions on data analytics. It has become clearer to me that it is part of my professional duty to support systems that support the flourishing of humans rather than algorithmic efficiency. The moral issues of digital consent have also become more apparent to me, thanks to the discussion of our group about Machiavellian power structures. I have now realized that to be truly independent, one needs more than a click-to-agree button: one needs a society that ensures the right to be

offline or anonymous without facing rejection by the modern economy. As a future professional, I will strive to find working conditions that can appreciate ethical data practices and the "privacy by design" concept. This project has shown me that every time we are constructing and utilizing technology, we need to pose the question, are we creating a world that Hobbes would be proud of, that is founded on fear and survival, or are we creating a place that Aristotle would point to as a good place in which human beings flourish?

5. Conclusion

What can be gained out of this project is that technology is never a neutral force, and it does take an active part in dictating the moral and political life of our lives. Working in a group, I also came to know that, when discussing such a complicated philosophical concept as the social contract or Eudaimonia, it is necessary to balance between empathy and critical thinking to find a ground on contemporary technical matters. Through this process, my communication skills were sharpened, and I was able to use abstract historical concepts to apply to real-world issues of the 21st century. I would consider, in the context of any future group work, delving further into varying case studies of surveillance so as to demonstrate the limits of the Aristotle concept of the so-called Golden Mean. At the end of it all, this report will support that though technology might evolve, the basic human requirement of autonomy and dignity will always exist.

Works Cited

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